Westbrook City Council

~ Special Meeting ~

Date: Monday, October 19, 2026
Time: 6:00 PM
Location: Westbrook High School (Room 114), 125 Stroudwater St. (Hybrid via Zoom)
Video: https://www.facebook.com/share/v/1ANedWMcfy/

*Timestamps below are **[H:MM:SS]** marks into that video.*

***This summary highlights the meeting's key discussions and decisions, with direct quotes and timestamps for verification — it is not a substitute for watching the full meeting.** Summarization necessarily condenses and selects; for complete context, nuance, and anything not covered here, watch the full video at the link above. (Produced by: WestbrookCurrents.com)*

II–IV. Roll Call, Pledge of Allegiance

Roll Call & Pledge [10:46]

Discussion Summary

President Jennifer Munro called the meeting to order. City Clerk Ellis Ledoux read the land acknowledgement statement and conducted roll call. All seven members — Councilors McCambridge, Shaughnessy (Vice President), Chau, Turcotte, Faulkingham, Rairdon, and President Munro — answered present. President Munro led the Pledge of Allegiance. No minutes were presented for approval.

Key Decisions

✓ Quorum established — all 7 members present.

Action Items

None.

V. Mayor's Message

Route 302 Corridor Study [12:21]

Discussion Summary

Chris Chop, Transportation Director for the Greater Portland Council of Governments, presented a regional safety and planning study covering the ~22-mile Route 302 corridor from I-295 in Portland to the Raymond–Casco town line, done jointly with Portland, Windham, Raymond, and the Maine Department of Transportation. The study is identifying high-crash locations, transit gaps, and candidate projects for future funding; it's still in the public-engagement and data-gathering phase.

President Munro (Ward 5) noted the Duck Pond Road stretch of Route 302 “can be scary at times… really hazardous.” Chop thanked her for the feedback.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational presentation — no vote taken.

Action Items
None.

Curbside Brush & Leaf Collection [23:34]

Discussion Summary
Director of Engineering & Public Services Eric Dudley reviewed this year's brush collection schedule (started that day, one pass through the city starting the following Friday) and leaf collection (starting the following Monday, biodegradable bags only, no tape, continuing through roughly early December weather permitting).

Key Decisions
✓ **Informational — no vote taken.**

Action Items
None.

Absentee Voting & Election Day (Nov. 3) [26:21]

Discussion Summary
City Clerk Ellis Ledoux reviewed absentee-voting deadlines (last day for no-excuse absentee voting: Friday, Oct. 29) and two extended evening hours at the Clerk's Office (Wed. Oct. 21 and Wed. Oct. 28, 7:30 am–7 pm). Election Day polls at the Westbrook Community Center run 6 am–8 pm.

Key Decisions
✓ **Informational — no vote taken.**

Action Items
None.

Parking Ordinance Review, Prospect Street, Shaughnessy Recognition & Student-Athlete Statement [27:10]

Discussion Summary
All part of the same continuous mayor's-message segment (one timestamp covers all three):

Parking/Prospect St.: Mayor Morse announced a staff review of the no-parking schedule against on-the-ground signage, plus an annual report to council on narrower-street parking designations. As part of the Prospect Street reconstruction (narrowing 28→26 ft for pedestrian/drainage improvements), the north side from Central St. East to the end of Prospect St. becomes no-parking; signs go up by month's end.

Recognition: Mayor Morse recognized Vice President Shaughnessy for the 2026 William F. King Jr. Downtown Champion Award from the Maine Development Foundation, citing his volunteer work with Discover Downtown Westbrook and Friends of the Presumpscot River.

Student-athlete statement: Mayor Morse addressed the recent use of student athletes' photographs in political attacks on social media, calling it “wrong” and praising the community's “overwhelming and nearly universal” rejection of the tactic. No council disagreement was voiced.

Key Decisions
✓ **Informational — no vote taken.**

Action Items
• Install no-parking signage on Prospect St. (north side) — Assignee: Public Services | Deadline: end of October 2026.

VI. City Council Messages

Meeting Start Time (6 pm vs. 7 pm) [33:05]

Discussion Summary

Councilor Turcotte asked when and why council meetings moved from a 7 pm to a 6 pm start, and whether council had actually voted on it. President Munro explained the 6 pm slot accommodates committee meetings that sometimes precede the council meeting. City Administrator Angela Holmes located the governing ordinance (Order 2024-146, adopted Dec. 16, 2024, amending Code of Ordinances §57-1): regular meetings keep a 6 pm start to allow a preceding committee meeting when needed. Turcotte requested that council consider a 7 pm start on nights without a committee meeting, calling it easier for families; Munro confirmed that is possible.

Key Decisions

✓ Informational discussion — no vote taken.

Action Items

• Consider adopting a 7 pm start on nights without a preceding committee meeting — Assignee: Council / Administrator Holmes | Deadline: none set.

VIII. Public Comment (First)

Recreation & Conservation Commission Rename (preview) [35:42]

Discussion Summary

David Von Segern, a departing Rec & Con Commission member speaking only for himself, previewed objections to Order 2026-116 (further below): renaming “conservation” to “sustainability”, and sequencing the ordinance rewrite before a new comprehensive plan is adopted. Matt Brunner, the Commission's chair, spoke next with a longer set of objections. See the full point/counterpoint under Order 2026-116 — both spoke before that order was formally read, which is why their timestamps are earlier than the order's.

Key Decisions

✓ Public comment — no vote taken at this stage.

Action Items

None.

X. Orders of the Day (Second & Final Reading)

Orders 2026-109, 110, 111, 112, 114 — Consent Block (Fire Truck Bid, Asset Forfeiture, Mill Brook Preserve, Rock Row Trail, Landslide Vendor List) [47:30]

Discussion Summary

Moved and seconded together by Councilor Rairdon: a $71,476 bid award to Casco Bay Ford for a replacement medium-duty fire department pickup truck; acceptance of $5,433.05 in federal asset-forfeiture funds; a $50,000 open-space-fund expenditure to the Presumpscot Regional Land Trust for Mill Brook Preserve accessibility improvements; a $10,000 open-space-fund expenditure to Portland Trails for the Rock Row Connector Trail;

and a vendor-list amendment on the roughly $1.1 million Presumpscot River Corridor landslide vulnerability assessment project (Maine Emergency Management Agency grant plus state match), following the September 2020 landslide. No discussion.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved as a block by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-113 — Credere Associates Task Order No. 11 — Riverwalk North (Supplemental Services) [49:36]

Discussion Summary

Pulled out of the consent block for separate consideration at Councilor Shaughnessy's request. Councilor Chau moved to amend the order to fund it via an FY24 U.S. Environmental Protection Agency Brownfields Cleanup Grant and to update the associated project vendor list; Shaughnessy seconded. Administrator Holmes explained the vendor list hadn't been updated in some time and needed a few more technical vendors added.

Key Decisions

✓ Amendment and order approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

XI. New Business

Resolve 2026-18 — Endorsing Community Development Block Grant Applications [51:12]

Discussion Summary

Administrator Holmes explained the city's two Community Development Block Grant applications: a $70,000 public-service grant for the Intercultural Community Center's Power School Family Stability Initiative (~110 low-income residents served), and a general application for 50% matching funds to update Brown Street reconstruction construction documents, tying in with the Riverwalk North project.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-115 — Memorandum of Understanding (MOU) with Quaker Lane Associates, LLC — Saccarappa Park [54:44]

Discussion Summary

Administrator Holmes outlined the MOU covering three items tied to Quaker Lane's adjacent mixed-use development at 7 Kidder Lane (110 market-rate apartments + 5,000 sq. ft. of commercial space): clearing/preparing the utility easement area, extending the boardwalk between Saccarappa Park and Kidder Lane, and installing a new fence (replacing barbed wire) along the fish ladder.

Key Decisions

✓ **Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.**

Action Items
None.

Order 2026-116 — Recreation & Conservation Commission Rewrite

[57:13] ***Found on page 77 of the packet.*** *Repeals the existing Recreation & Conservation Commission ordinance (Code of Ordinances Ch. 7, Art. 3) and replaces it with a Recreation & Sustainability Committee: drops 3 alternate seats (7 members retained), removes the state conservation-commission statute reference, sunsets all current members (who may reapply), and — per a floor amendment from the Oct. 5 Committee of the Whole — adds a one-year report-back on the new committee's performance.*

Why it's the meeting's one real controversy
Every other item passed without debate. This one drew two rounds of public comment, a sharp council exchange, a procedural clash with the chair, and the only non-unanimous vote of the night.

The case against (spoken during general public comment, before this order was formally read — see timestamps)

> *"I object to the replacement of conservation in the committee to be titled with sustainability. Sustainability is a term that is too often used by companies and government entities in various forms of greenwashing… These changes under consideration should have followed a new comprehensive plan."*

— David Von Segern, former Rec & Con Commission member (public comment) [35:42]

> *"[We requested a joint workshop with council.] It wasn't [scheduled]. Don't know why, I can guess, but I don't like to assume… rather than building roadblocks and taking the power of many and consolidating… those levers of power into the hands of a few. I don't think we like that when we see it a little south of us in D.C."*

— Matt Brunner, Chair, Recreation & Conservation Commission (public comment) [38:45]

> *"Our superpower is suggestion… our other superpower… has been holding the administration accountable for some things that were overlooked… I think to get rid of that check, that balance, is a dangerous and slippery slope."*

— Matt Brunner [38:45]

The counterpoint

> *"I do believe that at the heart of conservation is sustainability. They are very interchangeable… I really go and look at the duties and the charge of the committee… I would feel comfortable with that."*

— Councilor Michael Shaughnessy [1:16:26]

Shaughnessy proposed the amendment ultimately adopted with the order: a one-year report-back on how the new committee performs.

> *“We have been transparent through this whole process… it's going to be up to the council to decide whether or not you think we've hit the mark.”*

— City Administrator Angela Holmes [1:22:16]

Holmes' broader rationale: the ordinance has been in legal tension with the city charter's council/mayor authority since the commission's creation in 1970; the purpose/membership/duties/scope review was applied consistently across every city board and commission, not singled out here; and members may reapply, as happened when the Library Advisory Committee was previously restructured.

The dissent

> *“I've been observing this administration… removing a lot of the opportunities for our constituents to have a voice… this is probably the most disgusting thing I've seen on the council in the 11 years I've been on the council… I think it's underhanded, I think it's shady, I think it is incredibly disrespectful to the constituents… I will be voting against this regardless of how it goes.”*

— Councilor Anna Turcotte [1:19:00]

Turcotte also clashed procedurally with President Munro, who asked her to “focus on the merits of the issue and stop interrupting”:

> *“You can't shut me up, okay? I'm speaking… This is the second time you interrupted me. Point of order. This is disgusting.”*

— Councilor Anna Turcotte [1:21:37]

Mayor's rebuttal (defending staff, not re-arguing the policy)

> *“I just want to respond directly to the characterization of the city administration as corrupt, underhanded, or shady. Those are very serious accusations… an honest disagreement is not evidence of dishonesty. And a different judgment is not evidence of corruption.”*

— Mayor David Morse [1:30:10]

Follow-up from the public, after the vote context was set

> *“[Staff said] there's nothing that legally precludes this from happening. It's a fancy way of saying we don't have to do it… If time sensitivity was important here, I don't think we'd be sunsetting everybody, requiring new applications…”*

— Matt Brunner (second public comment) [1:35:30]

Key Decisions

✓ Approved 6–1 by roll call [1:41:51] (Councilor Turcotte dissenting), with Shaughnessy's one-year review amendment attached.

Action Items

• Open a new online application form for the Recreation & Sustainability Committee once adopted — Assignee: City Administration | Deadline: within the week following adoption.

• Report back to council in one year on the new committee's performance (per Shaughnessy's amendment) — Assignee: City Administration | Deadline: ~October 2027.

XI. New Business (continued)

Order 2026-117 — Mass Gathering Permit & Road Closure — Halloween on Main Street [1:42:05]

Discussion Summary

Main Street closure (Spring St. to Bridge St.) 4:15–6 pm, Friday, Oct. 30, for the Westbrook Together Days Committee's Halloween event. Councilor Chau thanked the volunteer committee for running it without city involvement. Councilor Rairdon raised safety concerns about e-bikes/scooters among pedestrians during the closure; Police Chief Lolly confirmed scooters aren't legally permitted on the roadway/sidewalks, officers will be present (including Capt. Goldberg), and it will be a point of emphasis.

Key Decisions

✓ Approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

Order 2026-118 — Bureau of Highway Safety Grant Funds (First Reading) [1:48:03]

Discussion Summary

Administrator Holmes detailed five sub-grants totaling the authorized amount ($40,351.60): drug-recognition-expert/forensic-phlebotomist training, impaired-driving campaigns, speed/aggressive-driving enforcement, pedestrian/motor-vehicle enforcement, and crash-reconstruction training. Thanked the police department for consistently pursuing these grants.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous show of hands. Second reading required.

Action Items

• Second and final reading — Assignee: Council | Deadline: next regular meeting.

Order 2026-119 — Drainage Easement at 41 Brown Street (First Reading) [1:50:41]

Discussion Summary

Authorizes an easement with Portland Water District to replace a failing box culvert (crossing into an unnamed stream feeding the Presumpscot) and maintain it going forward. The city is already under contract with Sebago Technics for the culvert's design.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous show of hands. Second reading required.

Action Items

• Second and final reading — Assignee: Council | Deadline: next regular meeting.

Order 2026-120 — Land Use Ordinance — Data Center Ban (First Reading) [1:52:13]

Discussion Summary

Data centers are currently permitted only within Contract Zone 12 (the Rock Row Contract Zone). Following a council-adopted 180-day moratorium on new data center projects (effective June 1, 2026) and a unanimous Planning Board recommendation, this amendment prohibits data centers as a principal use citywide (server rooms supporting other businesses remain allowed). Mayor Morse spoke in support, citing water/electricity demand, utility costs, noise, and infrastructure concerns.

Key Decisions

✓ Passed first reading, unanimous show of hands.

Action Items

• Public hearing and second reading — Assignee: Council | Deadline: November 2, 2026.

XII. Public Comment (Second) / XV. Executive Session

Closing Public Comment & Executive Session [1:55:35]

Discussion Summary

Chris Dudley (Ward 1) praised Administrator Holmes' communication style and raised the scooter-enforcement issue again. No online or other public comment. Council then voted to enter executive session under the Maine Revised Statutes Annotated (1 M.R.S.A. §405(6)(E)) for consultation with the City Solicitor on the legal rights and duties of the city; the transcript ends there.

Key Decisions

✓ Motion to enter executive session approved by unanimous roll call, 7–0.

Action Items

None.

How this was made

This summary was produced from the meeting video (linked above). The audio was downloaded with Downie 4 and transcribed with speaker diarization using MacWhisper. Claude (Anthropic's AI) cross-checked names against the official city council roster, attributed speakers from context (introductions, roll-call order, content) rather than the raw diarization labels alone, and drafted this summary and the quoted excerpts. Quotes are lightly cleaned of filler words/false starts but not reworded.

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